I never liked train stations.

To me, they were always places associated with sorrow and helplessness. It necessitated separation, no matter how temporary. Love it or hate it, you would inevitably be separated by a single door, hands separated by a single sheet of glass. And you wouldn't be able to do a thing.

All you could do was wave goodbye, and hope for a safe trip and the loved one's safe return.

I felt similarly helpless on the morning of Humphrey's departure, I remember it clearly. It was winter, the sun was nowhere in sight and an incredible blanket of snow had covered the face of the earth, for miles and miles beyond what I could see. A clean slate, a new beginning for Humphrey, I thought. Very symbolic.

I arrived at the station an hour in advance, having made up my mind to give him a proper send-off. I stared dumbly into the distance, trying my best to numb the swelling feeling of trepidation and sorrow. I loved him, but I hadn't told him yet. Time and time again, I had brushed it off, thinking that there would be another chance to tell him how I felt. But I was a step too late. I should have seen it coming, he certainly wasn't going to stay with me for my whole life. Who was I to stand in his way, to tell him not to go to Cambridge for his doctoral studies? He had planned to be a chemist, and a world-famous one at that. I had no right to make him stay.

My vision began to blur.

I exhaled sharply. I would send him off, bid him goodbye with a smile on my face. And as he leaves, I would find some way to make this inner turmoil cease, to let it rise and turn to mush, and bury it in the frigid winter.

Humphrey arrived shortly after, and so did the train. Without much of a chance to make small talk, I found myself standing face-to-face with him, in that ever so familiar yet uncomfortable situation, the separation of the glass door, the outstretched hand, the condensation atop the window pane, the single tear ruining my mascara.

It hurt to look at him.

With what I had, I looked at the man who I loved deeply. This was the end. I bit my tongue, desperately holding back the torrent that was to come.

With a mighty roar, the black train sent copious amounts of soot into the air - just as he had opened his mouth to speak. I couldn't hear him, but I could make out what he said through his lips and hands.

"Wait for me."

As the train pulled away from the station, I stood there, stunned, unsure of what to make of the situation. He loved me?

"Damn straight I did. Do you know what a terrible time it was to confess? Just as I was about to leave, it finally clicked that the girl that I loved loved me back. It was terrible! And you didn't even give me any hints, if I didn't confess then we'd-"

“Oh shut up! I know…” I continued to peel the apple while absentmindedly staring at the vast expanse of snow that lay beyond the window. It was the only source of sunlight permeating the dimly lit room, casting a shadow on my hunchbacked stature and some parts of Humphrey’s now frail figure. Machinery beeped, bopped, and whirred with methodical consistency. Outside, you could hear the footsteps of doctors, heavy with haste as they made their rounds across. But in those rare moments where everything died down, you could hear the pitter-patter of droplets from the nearby IV drip - but surely, one could find it within themselves to accept such a state as “peace and quiet”.

Humphrey sat forward. Closing his eyes, he let out a guttural cough, a phlegmy one. But nothing came out. He leaned back into the inclined bed again, and draped two blankets over himself.

“Don’t wipe your mouth using the blanket. Here, I have tissue.”

Humphrey let out a weak smile. “Honey, I just want you to know… I’m so glad I didn’t let you go. I’ve been blessed to have spent my life with you, and I wouldn’t have it any other way. If ever I loved you my darling, tis now.”

“Ee eurgh, so cheesy. I’ll head to the toilet.”

When I returned to the ward, Humphrey was already asleep. He was smiling. His hair, now white and spotting, was a far cry from the luscious, thick black curls of hair I used to comb through. His beard, once stubble, was now long strands of white. His face was slightly wrinkled, pocked with inexplicable black spots. All evidence of decades of hard work for our family. For me.

This was the man I loved, who I had given my youth to, with whom I grew old with.

I eyed the machine with the green line as my thoughts began to drift. Today, just like that day, was frigid. Cloudy sky, a blanket of snow, hearts desperately seeking warmth. We share a kiss - our last on this station, my cheeks against his, smooth on stubble for a moment. And then it’s gone. I must go, I hear him mutter.

Something twinges inside me. Every fiber in me wants to shout and scream, “Stop”, to run across to him and take him in my arms, holding him tight, preventing the inevitable from elapsing.

“I love you, you silly, silly man, I love you.”

But he must go. I am armed with the comfort that he truly does love me back, yet woefully unequipped for the helplessness of solitude. I can only stand still. This time, he doesn’t even look back - I see only the curls on the back of his head, bobbing slightly as he steps out of my line of sight, forever.

As the train once again pulls away from the station, I can no longer hear the usual furore accompanying every departure - the wailing of the engine, the intrepid footsteps of people chasing after the train, the sniffles of women holding in their tears, toddler in hand. No, there is only the sound of a machine, with its soft, constant high-pitched humming. The train slowly gains speed, following the natural contour of the land - it climbs a small hill, enters a small trough, and gradually reappears as it makes its voyage along the smooth, straight path, slowly but surely perishing beyond the horizon, till it reaches its destination - a place of new beginnings, a station of joy - till our paths once again intertwine.

“Wait for me.”